

Teacher Attrition in the Seven CPF Countries

How Often Do Teachers Leave the Profession, and How Do We Know?

José Elías Durán Roa University of Alicante and OECD July 2026

The Comparative Panel File (CPF) harmonizes the seven longest-running national household panels: the PSID (United States), BHPS/Understanding Society (United Kingdom), SOEP (Germany), HILDA (Australia), KLIPS (South Korea), RLMS-HSE (Russia), and SHP (Switzerland). For each of the seven countries, this note assembles the annual rate at which school teachers leave the teaching profession, contrasting at least three independent within-country sources per country—administrative censuses and registers, household and follow-up surveys, and academic studies—about twenty-five sources in all. Table 1 summarizes the country-level answer; Table 2 lists the underlying sources.

Three regularities organize the evidence. First, within every country the measured rate falls along the same definitional ladder: gross separations from individual schools exceed exits from the school sector, which exceed exits from the profession, which exceed definitive exits net of returns, which exceed voluntary quits. Most of the apparent disagreement between sources disappears once definitions are aligned; in Switzerland, for example, the 8.4 percent of teachers who leave the school registers each year shrinks to 1–2 percent once retirements and the 61 percent of under-55 leavers who return within four years are netted out. Second, attrition scales inversely with civil-service protection: voluntary quits are nearly nil where teachers are tenured civil servants (Korea 0.2–0.3 percent, German Beamte 0.2 percent) and the all-cause rate rises from about 2 percent in Korea to 5 percent in Australia, 4–6 percent in Russia, 7.5–8 percent in the United States, and roughly 9 percent leaving the state-funded sector in England. The United States sits at the high end of the distribution but is no outlier. Third, the household panels of the CPF themselves are largely unable to measure teacher attrition: no published teacher-exit rate exists for the PSID, SOEP, KLIPS, RLMS-HSE, or SHP, whose per-wave teacher samples are too small, and where household-panel estimates do exist they run roughly double the administrative benchmark (12.3 percent in Understanding Society against 9 percent in the English workforce census; 11.6 percent in HILDA against 5 percent in Australian tax records), a gap that Australian work traces to occupational miscoding between waves. This is precisely the measurement problem the March CPS design avoids—one instrument, annual, public, validated person by person against panel classifications—and it is why the retrospective instrument, not the household panels, carries the burden of measurement in this literature. Everywhere, finally, stated intentions vastly overstate behavior: 36–39 percent of Australian teachers intend to leave and about 5 percent do; 87 percent of Korean teachers have considered leaving and 0.2–0.3 percent resign.

Table 1. Annual Teacher Profession-Leaving Rates in the CPF Countries

Country (CPF panel)	Best estimate	Years	Range across sources
United States (PSID)	7.5–8	2000s–2024	5–13.5
United Kingdom (UKHLS)	~9 ^a	2022/23–2024/25	5–12.3
Germany (SOEP)	5–5.5 ^b	2010/11–2024/25	0.2–11.8
Australia (HILDA)	~5 ^c	2009–2021	1.3–11.6
South Korea (KLIPS)	~2 ^d	2019–2024	0.1–2.1
Russia (RLMS-HSE)	4–6 ^e	2016–2024	<1–14.4
Switzerland (SHP)	7–8 ^f	2010–2021	1–8.4

Notes: Percent of the teacher stock leaving the teaching profession per year; “range” spans all credible within-country sources under their own definitions. ^aShare leaving the state-funded sector (England); genuine profession exit is an estimated 5–8 percent. ^bPermanent exits from the school service including regular retirement; voluntary quits are 0.2–0.4 percent. ^cAll-cause; 4.5 percent among working-age teachers (21–64). ^dDepartures before statutory retirement age, dominated by honorary early retirement; voluntary resignations are 0.2–0.3 percent. ^eEarly-career cohort exit is firmly documented at about 6 percent; official gross school separations (14.4 percent in 2023) conflate profession exit with school-to-school moves. ^fGross annual exits from the school registers, of which about 3 points are retirements; definitive profession-leaving of under-55s is 1–2 percent after re-entries. *Source:* Author’s compilation, July 2026; sources in Table 2.

Table 2. Underlying Sources, by Country

Country	Source / dataset	Definition	Years	Annual rate (%)
United States	NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey (TFS/NTPS)	left K–12 teaching, public	1988–2022	5.6 → 7.4–8.4; 8.0 (2021–22)
	March CPS: Harris–Adams; Aldeman–Yi	occupation exit, all sectors	1992–2001; 2015–24	7.7; 7.6
	State admin.: Washington S-275; Texas PEIMS	leaving state teaching workforce	1985–2025	5–8 (WA); 9–13.5 (TX)
	Learning Policy Institute (SASS/TFS)	leavers	2011–13	~8
United Kingdom	DfE School Workforce Census (England)	leaving state-funded sector	2010/11–24/25	8.5–10.6
	NFER (SWC; excl. retirements)	working-age sector exit	2022/23	8.8
	NFER on Understanding Society	profession exit, panel	2009–17	12.3 (upper bound)
	GTC Scotland; EWC Wales registers	de-registration	2024–25	~5; ~4.5–5
Germany	Destatis Fachserie 11 / FiBS	permanent exits from school service	2010/11–24/25	~5.4 (gross 9.5–11.8)
	Destatis pension statistics	new teacher retirements (Beamte)	2003–23	~2–3
	Länder data (NRW, BW)	voluntary resignation	2013–24	0.2 (Beamte); 2–2.4 (angestellte)
Australia	e61 Institute, PLIDA/BLADE tax data	not teaching in any of next 3 years	2009–21	5.9 → 5.1; 4.5 working-age
	AITSL ATWD registration data	registration discontinuation	2019–23	~1.3 (early-career)
	HILDA (Cuervo–Vera-Toscano)	occupation exit, panel	2001–22	11.6 (upper bound)
	NSW CESE; Queensland College of Teachers	employer separations; register removal	2006–19	3.7–5.3; ~3.6
South Korea	MOE/KEDI administrative data	pre-retirement departures; resignations	2019–24	1.5–2.1; 0.2–0.3
	Jung et al. (2021), provincial panel OECD TALIS 2024 (KEDI)	profession exit, public elementary 5-year leaving intention	2009–18 2024	<2 ≤1.2 implied
Russia	Minprosveshcheniya form OO-1	school separations (incl. moves)	2017–23	10.7 → 14.4 (upper bound)
	HSE graduate-employment panels Tochno.st (OO-1/Rosstat)	school-system exit, early career net stock change; education-sector exit	2016–24 2016–25	5.9–6.9 –0.9 net; ~2.4
Switzerland	BFS LABB, Mobilität (2014)	exit from school service	2010–11	8.4; 16 first-year
	BFS LABB, Verbleib (2022)	under-55 school-employment exit	2015/16–20/21	~2 (~1 definitive)
	Canton Zürich; Herzog–Sandmeier; SKBF	system exit ≤54; profession exits; retirements	2016–24	~7; 7–8; 3

Notes: One row per source family; rates as reported by each source under its own definition, in percent of the relevant teacher stock per year. Arrows denote change over the period. “Upper bound” marks household-panel estimates inflated by occupational coding churn between waves. Intention measures are excluded except the TALIS row, shown as an implied upper bound. For the PSID, SOEP, KLIPS, RLMS-HSE, and SHP no published teacher-exit rate exists; those countries rely on administrative sources. Full citations and URLs in the replication file `outputs/cpf_teacher_attrition.md`. *Source:* Author’s compilation from the sources listed, July 2026.